

it's a free portal for both the donors and the needy.

Somani sums up the purpose of the site: "There are many NGOs doing excellent work in India. We wanted to support them in whatever capacity, be it online or offline, in volunteering, distributing materials or providing strategic advice. NGOs are largely understaffed. We hoped that visitors to Karmayog.com, who may be experts in their own field, could provide their valuable time and efforts to support a noble cause."

Volunteers, mentors, corporates, and service providers can list the availability of their time, talent, materials, services and money, and indicate their interest in specific humanitarian projects.

The Karmayog team co-ordinates events and seminars that includes contacting NGOs, citizens, the BMC, the Mantralaya, and corporates—and all forthcoming events are listed on the site.

The Team

Apart from Somani, the Karmayog team has five other members. There's Vibha Singh, the content developer, a journalist with eight years of experience in mainstream media and in the social sector. What prompted Singh to join Karmayog?

She replies, "The media doesn't have scope for follow-ups. For instance, if I reported a rape, the story would be printed, but that would be the end of it. How the victim was rehabilitated, and other such relevant issues would go unnoticed.

I realised then that it were the NGOs who finally rehabilitated the victims—of rape or otherwise—and they were the ones who actually did the follow-ups. I wanted to do something more constructive than just report facts as they stood. I chose to work with Karmayog.com since other similar Web sites seemed inadequate."

Other team players include management student Burzin Mistry, who handles the Web site development. A post-graduate in social work, John Matthew is the researcher. Jayant Upadhyay manages accounts and administration, along with Falguni Chauhan, the accounts executive.

On The Technical Front

The Web site itself is constantly undergoing change. While it doesn't have a forum, there's a full-fledged Yahoo! Group with more than 3,000 active members.

As Mistry says, "When first launched, Karmayog.com was a purely HTML site, a database model. We developed it over time into a fully-functional portal. For now, we have outsourced the programming work. We also send out a free daily newsletter. We use Google's AdSense for revenue generation, and have also implemented SEO (Search Engine Optimisation). We get more than a thousand page views daily."

An Information Database

Visitors to Karmayog.com can find volunteers, advisors, employees, materials, services, sponsors, Indian and foreign donors, and get support for



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Vinay Somani
 Founder,
 Karmayog.com

events and publications. There is also a list of companies in India involved in Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR).

Highlights of Karmayog.com include 'Hot Topics', wherein urgent social issues are floated online and users can add their views, suggest solutions or offer assistance. Other links include 'Issues/Causes', 'Actions for Citizens' including 'Contact your ALM (Advanced Locality Management), and so on. Under 'Services' are listed emergency numbers, help lines, 152 support groups and an all-India hospital list.

A recent addition is the 'NGO Council', a representative body of the NGO sector in Mumbai. An open committee, it comprises a mix of 69 organisations. The Karmayog team has extensively mapped and sorted the NGO sector in Mumbai by location, area of work, capacity, activities and so on.

Singh adds, "As a Web site, you need to have the latest information. This involved personally visiting hundreds of NGOs and calling others to check if their services, addresses and phone numbers were still valid. To post data about non-NGOs, we took up whatever existing lists there were, of say, blood banks, media firms and hospitals. Then, we called up every institution to verify the details and uploaded those on to the site."

A Web Presence For NGOs

NGOs in India can get a free, permanent, self-manageable online presence at the site: the NGO is given a URL such as—

www.karmayog.com/ngoname. The NGO can update its details daily, put up requests for volunteers, and announce job openings amongst other details.

Somani explains, "Being on the Web increases an NGO's reach. The details of the listed NGO have been presented in such a way that it gives users a quick profile of the organisation. As of now, Karmayog has up-to-date listings of more than 2,000 NGOs in Mumbai alone—and more than 3,000 NGOs from the rest of India."

Karmayog also lists volunteers and donors. There are more than 350 registered volunteers, and the number is rising. Those who would like to get volunteer IDs from Karmayog need to fill an online form mentioning their name, work and home



The Karmayog team (standing from left to right): Burzin Mehta, Vinay Somani, Jayant Upadhyay, John Matthew and (seated from left to right) Falguni Chauhan and Vibha Singh

Photograph: Jiten Gandhi